

MY TWENTY-FIVE YEARS MEMOIR

Ca Đoàn Đồng Tâm

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An old friend once told me, “Không phải sự ngẫu nhiên mà anh có mặt ở nơi đây với gia đình chúng tôi”—is there such a thing as a “coincidence” that we meet?

Twenty-five years later, I still remember you. The memories of our past bring back images of familiar faces long ago, and once upon a time, we were together, singing four-part choral music (soprano, alto, tenor, and bass). It’s a bittersweet feeling; I’m happy and sad all at once, hoping that one day we will meet again.

Having the chance to see and reconnect with all those young, beautiful, and not-so-handsome faces, to share old memories and the adventures of our lives—family, achievements, and more—is a true honor. I want to take this opportunity to express my gratitude; you have profoundly impacted my life and who I am, and I am grateful to call you my friend. Is such an opportunity possible? No matter where you have been over the past 25 years, I hope you still remember the good old days when we shared laughter and joy together.

Twenty-five years came to mind as old memories poured into my consciousness—like whispers in the wind, searching for something significant. Having accomplished something meaningful, one can earn recognition for their contributions. Reflecting critically on my life's journey, it’s clear that there are very few moments in anyone's lifetime when they have the opportunity to witness or achieve something truly significant, deserving of honor, acknowledgment of a "job well done," or recognition as an extraordinary person.

While responsibilities such as family, parenting, career, and education are expected of any responsible individual, the untold stories of our lives often fade into distant memories. Yet, we remain a mystery—assumed heroes in our own right.

Additionally, there are only a handful of occasions in life when we can reunite with those who have shared in our experiences and journey together. To revisit our past, enjoying laughter, sharing tears, or even offering apologies, would be a remarkable opportunity if only it were true.

The familiar place is no longer here, and everyone has moved on with their life as usual, but the old memories live on. Have you ever wondered why the old memories make you smile, happy, and/or even sad? Amazingly, as tough as life can be, the old memories and the friendships along the way are treasured, which you can carry with you wherever you are. Have you or someone you know done something of significance? Yes, I want to hear your story and celebrate all of your successes. Twenty-five years is a quarter of a century; there are surely many amazing stories to tell. As unique as we all are, we have shared a common bond of friendship and brotherhood, and that is an amazing story already. The evidence is that you are part of my memory, and from the experiences of knowing you, you help shape my life.

Would you like to tell someone “Yes, I can’t wait to tell you the story of my life and my accomplishments”? My successes are very much your effort in being in my life. My story began with you, and my journey would not be the same without you. All of you have helped shape me into the person I am today. This is what I would like to tell you. Having the opportunity to share my life story and accomplishments with you and to hear

yours is the best gift anyone could have. Starting with the first hello marks the beginning of the lifetime of friendship, and remembering those people who, in one way or another, have shared our journey and made us proud.

Would you also like to thank someone in person for being part of your life's journey? It is an honor to recognize those individuals who have significantly impacted your life or organization, and they deserve our gratitude. This serves as a valuable lesson for the younger generation, helping to continue the 25-year tradition of success. Imagine the legacy we could create if we acknowledged those who have made a significant difference in our lives. To you, my friend, I say thank you—thank you!

As we reflect on the memories of our lives, we realize that what we see is not merely a result of chance or luck. It is shaped by the contributions of those who came before us. One meaningful way to show our appreciation for the older generation is to thank them for their sacrifices and hard work. In doing so, we can also look forward to a brighter future, working to build a better world for our children, ensuring that both their legacies and ours will endure.

Twenty-five years is a considerable amount of time. Many in the younger generation have yet to reach that milestone, and they may have only a few memories from their early years. Let's make this moment one that we want to be remembered for. Each of us should ask ourselves: Where do you see yourself in the next 25 years, and how do you want to be remembered?

Five, twenty-five, fifty, seventy-five, and a century—where are you in the five? At age 5, when a baby becomes a child, they start dreaming about what they want to be: "I want to be a doctor, a teacher, a veterinarian, an artist, an architect, or even a priest." There

is a long way between the ages of five and twenty-five. This is the time when your parents will try to encourage you to stay out of trouble, join the choir, hang out with friends, or study harder to become a doctor, etc. Believe it or not, only a few of us answer God's call to the priesthood. We are blessed with many gifts, friendships, and the opportunity to live in exciting times.

Reflecting back when you dreamers were teenagers, you fell in love and felt as if you were in heaven. Then came heartbreak, you tasted reality for the first time, and it was not fun, was it? Did you ever want to say, "I don't want to grow up anymore"? As you moved on, you graduated from college and felt ready to take on the world. Ouch, that reality hurt. Life had just kicked you in the "butt." You got laid off. Welcome to reality.

Then came family and kids, and what a beautiful family you had! Ouch, that hurt again. Once more, life had kicked you in the "butt." That wasn't enjoyable! At that time, didn't you wish you had listened to your parents when they said, "Cha Hiền đi tu cho rồi? You might have wondered about the fathers—Cha Hiền, Cha Cường, Cha Thiên Ân, Cha Trùng, and Cha Vũ—who are part of this great circle of friendship.

The essence of the different stages of our lives is not merely about what has occurred, but about how a dreamer learns to get back up (and sometimes with help from friends) and move on. Where are you now?

To understand where you are now, you must know where you come from. My twenty-five-year memoir really begins here. By now, you may be questioning who this wise guy is and why he is lecturing us about life, especially when the fathers, whom we call 'Fathers,' are part of this great friendship circle. This story isn't about them; it is about

my life and my recollection over the past twenty-five years—where I have been and where I am now.

I don't want to be seen as a smart aleck, but I want to share the real me that you have helped shape. I aim to express my memoir in the true sense of my past twenty-five years. To those who know me, you may recall my saying "chơi bằng và không chơi hơn bạn," or maybe you haven't heard me say "you are wrong." I believe in every experience being a gift, in everyone being created equal in capacity, in respecting others' individuality, in accepting individual differences, in fostering friendships, in lifelong learning, in sharing knowledge, and in seizing the first opportunity that comes my way. Denying who you are is essentially denying your essence. That is who I am, and I hope to have made you proud.

Even Father Hiền was uncertain about how the other first-generation "tứ quái" and I would turn out. He once said, "You guys are a host of different personalities; I'm not sure how you all will turn out." In response, Father, you also once told me, "I am happy to be wrong. Thanks, God." Thank you for those words of wisdom. I'm not sure if they were mere words of encouragement, but they inspired me to be the best person I can be. Father, I hope to have made you proud.

When reflecting on the 25th anniversary of Ca Doan Dong Tam, I realize I have only 24 years of memories to share. My 24 years with this community have been incredibly exciting. I can only imagine how thrilling the first year must have been, starting with a young priest, Cha Hien, and a group of "sao biển" who were the first choir members. Many of them were much younger than I am now. I've often wondered about the origin of the name "Đồng Tâm," and I would love to hear the story behind it. Thanks to the

group of “tứ quái,” I can confidently say that without “các Anh,” my life and who I have become would be very different.

In 1986, my family—my mom, two sisters, two brothers, and I—moved from Ohio to San Jose. At first, I didn’t like San Jose. We were poor and didn’t have a real place to call home; we shared two rooms with a relative. Somehow, my mom was able to get my sister and me to join Ca Đoàn Đồng Tâm, and that’s when my life began to change. Coming from a displaced family, with my father still in a “re-educational camp” in Vietnam, a good future felt distant, education seemed out of reach, and I didn’t consider myself very “smart.” I admired “các Anh” for their gifts in music, sports, academics, and more. They possessed everything I could only dream of being.

My father’s absence was difficult, and growing up during my teenage years was even tougher. I wanted to be like my peers, with both a mother and a father. I looked up to “các Anh” as role models, seeing in them the qualities of good people: kindness, generosity, fun, athleticism, and so on. I even fancied the cars they drove at the time. They were there when I needed someone to look up to, like a big brother. I fondly remembered my eagerness for choir practice each Saturday, wanting to emulate “các Anh.”

How could I forget the old sack at St. Maria Goretti, where Ca Doan Dong Tam held choir practice, or the tree where we gathered? I can’t forget “các Anh”: Anh, Biên, “Bác Hồ,” Các, Dũng, Hùng, Luật, Linh, Lịch, Long, Minh, Sánh, Vinh, Thao, Thái, Trị, Tuyển, and many more. I also cherish the memories of “các Chi”: Bích, Cúc, Dung, Huyền, Khương, Mến, Mai, Nhung, Ngọc Lan, Nguyệt Lan, Nguyệt, Lan Anh, Linh, Sử, Thiên Hương, Thiên Trang, Trang, “út” Tuyết, Vân, Vi, Yêu, the long list keeps growing. I

can't forget the first generation of "tứ quái": me, Duy, Hoàng, Phước, and Tuấn, who joined later. Together, we began a new generation of "tứ quái," with two eventually becoming Fathers.

I fondly remember our summer camping trips to Yosemite, Big Basin, and all the picnics and gatherings we enjoyed together. I cherish the celebrations we shared, from our Christmas and New Year's parties to the weddings of "các Anh and cá Chị." I will never forget how all of you, along with Father Hien, sang at my wedding. I admit I was the emotional "chu re" and shed tears of joy as these memories flooded back. How could I forget? There are countless other memories from my time with Ca Doan Dong Tam that I still hold dear today. Thank you all for being a part of my life and for your cherished friendship!

Over the past 25 years, many people in my life have helped make my dream of becoming a person of faith, a good person, and a loving family member and friend come true. First, I want to give thanks to the Almighty for granting me intellectual ability and the capacity to be my best.

Second, I would like to express my deep appreciation to my wife, Thaivi, and my children, Sean, Bethany, and Mary, for their love and support and, most importantly, for their patience with me over the years. You are my inspiration and the driving force behind my desire to achieve my very best.

Third, I want to thank my parents for their unwavering love and sacrifices throughout their lives, which have made my future brighter than theirs. They have undoubtedly shaped me into the person I am today.

I am also grateful to my extended family, especially my siblings and my dearest friends, including Ca Đoàn Đồng Tâm, and many others. I would not have come this far without your friendship. Life is a journey, and each of you has made that journey more enjoyable. Thank you!

I would like to take this opportunity to share my experiences with my children, nieces, nephews, friends, and the younger generation of Ca Đoàn Đồng Tâm who don't know me. My advice is to take every opportunity seriously, as it might not come again. I have always seized my first opportunity, and I have no regrets about the paths I have chosen. I remain optimistic about the future.

To me, a successful person is someone who is not afraid of hard work and knows when to say no to the wrong things. I live by two guiding principles: 1) Do what you are supposed to do, and 2) Be responsible for your actions. I hope my children will remember me with the words, "my dad once said..."

While I may not fit the conventional definition of success, I can proudly say that I have a wonderful family—my wife, Thaivi, with whom I have been married for 12 years, and our three beautiful children: Sean (10), Bethany (9), and Mary (3). I work for Oracle Corporation as a Principal Engineer. Additionally, I have been teaching Computer Science courses at Ohlone College for 12 years.

Starting as a “C” student at a community college, I accomplished all of this while also advancing my education. I have been blessed with many good friends, and it often feels like God sent them my way. Life has been kind to me, largely because my faith is very important, and I adopt a "can-do attitude" while fulfilling my responsibilities. These are my recipes for success, and they work for me.

To all of you, I offer this suggestion: “Pick one thing and do it well.” You will succeed!

I am now 41 years old, and my chosen path has guided me to this moment. I stand before you as a product of not just chance, luck, or sheer intelligence, but of learnable intelligence. This is not the end for me; my journey continues with a “can-do attitude” and, most importantly, a commitment to lifelong learning. All of you have played a part in my successes.

My next endeavor is to make a difference in at least one person's life. I understand what it feels like to be lost and in need of guidance, like a big brother. Having experienced many challenges throughout my life—growing up during the Vietnam War, coming from a displaced family, being a “boat person,” and living as a refugee—has shaped my perspective on the opportunities presented to me. I took my first opportunity, and it paid off.

Now, I hold four academic degrees: a) a Liberal Arts, b) a Bachelor of Science in Computer Engineering, c) a Master of Science in Software Engineering, and d) a Doctorate. These achievements did not come without a great deal of hard work and responsibility. As I noted in my 25-year memoir, the turning point in my life began at Ca Doan Dong Tam, and I am grateful to all of you who helped guide me here.

As we look forward to the next twenty-five years, I’m reminded that I’m not quite there yet, but I hope to see all of you at the 50th anniversary celebration as well. Some of the older members of Ca Doan Dong Tam may already be in their fifties or beyond. Are you starting to feel old, or are you still waiting for the right opportunity? Don’t wait too

long; we only have a few 25th anniversaries left. Let's make this 25th celebration one for the books—a moment that you will want to be remembered for.

What kind of legacy do you wish to leave for the next generation of Ca Đoàn Đồng Tâm members, or perhaps for your own children? They may also find it difficult to understand that there was a time when you were truly great!

Where do I stand now? I am a former member of Ca Đoàn Đồng Tâm, and like many others who have moved on with their lives, I have focused on family, career, school, and navigating daily challenges. However, the experiences and friendships I formed during my 25 years with the group have profoundly impacted my life. This is my story, and I would love to share it with you in person. Thank you for being a part of my journey! I am eager to hear about your experiences at the Ca Đoàn Đồng Tâm 25th anniversary celebration.

Back to reality and to conclude my 25-year memoir, I find myself returning to life as usual. Congratulations to Ca Đoàn Đồng Tâm on its 25th anniversary! Without this special occasion and A. Dũng, who first planted this idea in my mind, I wouldn't have had the chance to share my fond memories. Is there such a thing as an "accident"? I think not. What I have written in this memoir is now known to the world. It's an amazing story, and I have always tried to seize every opportunity to express these experiences, and this is no exception. So, what are you waiting for?

To: Ca Doan Dong Tam members from far and near
RE: CA DOAN DONG TAM 25 YEARS ANNIVERSARY

Next year is the Ca Doan Dong Tam 25th anniversary. When people talk about anniversaries, they often think of 5, 10, 15, 20, or 25 years or more. Twenty-five years mark a major milestone for any organization. What have we accomplished over the 25 years?

Over the past 25 years, many of the old members have moved on, started families, and gone on with life as usual. Many young, pretty faces with beautiful voices are not so young anymore, and their once-beautiful voices may be hard to hear. Now, you are being replaced by the next generation of Ca Đoàn Đồng Tâm members with better-looking faces and much better voices.

Gone with the oldies and coming with the new members, it is the cycle of nature. There is an old saying, “tre già măng mọc”. As for the younger generation of Ca Doan Dong Tam members, they take charge and move forward with much the same mission: helping the people of God celebrate Mass more “suốt sáng”.

Would you like to know who the people are who have gone before you or meet the next generation of Ca Doan Dong Tam members? We want to hear from all of you, old, new, and not so old. We want to know who you are, where you have been, and anything new in your life.

Life is a journey. Twenty-five is just like “gone with the wind”. Many people come and go, or just pass by (CDDT), but you still remember the good old days when you were once there.

There are few moments in our lives when we have the opportunity to be in a specific place and time, witnessing the impact we have made on individuals or organizations. Ca Doan Dong Tam is still active, and we now have four priests who are former members. What is your accomplishment? We would like to celebrate our 25th anniversary with you.